



Epoch-making performance: Thom Gicquel and Delphine Delrue in full flight on their way to a historic mixed doubles triumph in New Delhi. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

elite talent. Before he got into administration, Gombrowicz was coach of Erwin Kehlhoffner, who lost 21-10 21-6 to China's Chen Jin at the 2008 Olympics. Back then, French badminton was largely a club-based sport when it came to producing elite players.

France then established its first national performance centre, followed by two more national centres for young players and nine regional centres for younger athletes. The federation now works with approximately 60 clubs around the country and has invested heavily in coach education and high-performance support.

Gombrowicz said there are

around 100 to 120 coaches involved in high-level work, while the system has increasingly incorporated data, training-load management and game planning.

The objective was not simply to find talented badminton players. It was to create an environment in which those players could become world-class. "We worked hard step by step and now we have arrived for the first world title," Gombrowicz said, speaking after Gicquel and Delrue's gold.

While the gold medals at the World Championships were historic, there had been signs for some time that the French system was beginning to produce something

special. French men's singles player Christo Popov won the World Tour Finals last year while Lanier was the European singles champion. Perhaps more significant was the bronze Gicquel and Delrue won at the World Championships last year. It was an important milestone: France's first world medal produced by its own system. France had previously had a world bronze through Pi Hongyan in 2009, but her development had taken place in China before she moved to France at around 20.

The difference mattered to Gombrowicz. And then Lanier added another. The 21-year-old is perhaps the clearest example of the French